530 by 2030, as compared with just 288 US Navy ships in 2019. While many of its naval ships are smaller, new and powerful cruisers and guided missile destroyers, such as the Type 055, are being built at a rapid pace (nearly double the rate of US ships being put to sea), and the Chinese outclass their US counterparts in advanced antiship missiles.[40] Despite the world welcoming China's rise and doing all it can to integrate it into global economic and political systems, Beijing sees enemies all around it and believes it needs an overwhelming military capability to deal with a world intent on containing it. This is traceable directly to the worldview and ideology of the CCP, which must assume a permanent counterrevolutionary vigilance to root out those at home and abroad who would destroy the communist system.[41]

This feeling of insecurity and frustration with the restrictions of international law have led China to rely on its military capability to undermine or slowly chip away at the positions of countries with which it has disputes. As Beijing has gained power, it has threatened and intimidated its neighbors and begun to act assertively, even aggressively, in the waters of East Asia so as to ensure outcomes to its liking. Its primary goal is to prevent the erosion of what it considers its territorial integrity, regardless of geopolitical complexities and questions of sovereignty or independence. The greatest threat to the CCP's sense of China's integrity is the shadow of Taiwanese independence. The Chinese government has increased its propaganda and interference operations during Taiwanese elections and in its media, and has directly threatened a military response should the island even hold a referendum on independence.[42] It continues to steadily peel away Taiwan's few remaining diplomatic partners, usually through lavish aid packages and other monetary inducements. All this is designed to isolate Taiwan and make it a de facto province of the mainland. It is par for the course for Beijing to condemn US sales of defense equipment to Taiwan as a violation of the 1970s-era "one China" principle. As relations between Washington and Beijing have worsened, however, the Chinese government ratcheted up the pressure, announcing in July 2019 that it would sanction US companies